By all accounts, Suu Kyi was a serious student, proud of her Burmese heritage. She for the most part rejected the decadent lifestyle of 1960s university life. Suu Kyi majored in politics, philosophy, and economics. Ironically, while studying abroad in Great Britain, Burmese democracy was collapsing at home. Interestingly, Suu Kyi avoided politics for the most part. She did not speak out about the Vietnam War or become involved in any way with campus protests or demonstrations. She also did not socialize very much with the Burmese community in or around the campus. Aung San Suu Kyi graduated from Oxford with honors in 1967.

Aung San Suu Kyi was uncertain about her career path and direction. She ultimately moved to New York City in 1969. Suu Kyi took a job with the United Nations working for the Advisory Committee on Administrative and Budgetary Questions. She simultaneously worked on an English Literature degree at New York University. Suu Kyi shared an apartment with Ma Than E, a family friend. This was an advantageous time to work at the United Nations since the Secretary-General U Thant was Burmese. Suu Kyi stayed at the organization for three years.

While at the United Nations, Suu Kyi kept in contact with future Tibetan scholar Michael Aris whom she had known during their time together at Oxford University. After a long period of correspondence, she visited him in Bhutan in 1970. She returned to New York engaged. They married in 1972 and Suu Kyi subsequently left her job in New York at the UN to join Michael. His studies took the couple from Bhutan back to Oxford for several years. During this time, the couple had two children: Alex in 1973 and Kim in 1977.

Aung San Suu Kyi published several academic essays and in 1984 she authored a brief biography of her late father. In 1985, Aung San Suu Kyi won a scholarship to study at the University of Kyoto in Japan. The family eventually moved to India where Michael was a visiting fellow at the Indian Institute for Advanced Studies. Suu Kyi was about to begin graduate work on Burmese literature at London University's School of Oriental and Asian Studies when she was called back home to Burma to deal with her ailing mother who had suffered a stroke. Upon her arrival, she never became involved nor made public statements regarding the politics in Burma.